surges. They didn't pre-empt future surges and hence displayed this lacklustre attitude in installing them too. It was only during the time of the second wave when patients were stranded did they raise urgent requests for more units.

Now let us take Rajasthan's case as an example. The ventilators sent to Rajasthan from the PM CARES fund were further rented to private hospitals. The Centre had sent ventilators for every district in Rajasthan but the government of Rajasthan rented these out to private entities for ₹2,000 per day. Hence, the ventilator which was supposed to be used for free treatment for the common man was used to extract ₹50,000 per patient for treatment.[54] In another district—Churu in Rajasthan, the audit team dispatched by the Centre found that unopened boxes of ventilators were lying near the washroom area in a public hospital, eventually rendering them unusable. According to the management, they had no space to put them hence they chose to keep them near the toilets.[55] In Kotlipur, near Jaipur, ventilators remained unused due to the lack of adequate oxygen supply. What is unfortunate is that the chief minister of Rajasthan was quick to point fingers at the Centre for sending defective pieces before putting his own house in order![56]

Now let us also note that all of this narrative and media mud-slinging regarding ventilators took place in a limited time frame—the first three weeks of May. When the country was already struggling to control the second surge of the virus, it was generally easier for chief ministers to point fingers at the Centre versus being accountable and answering the public about their complacency and pandemic mismanagement.

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The Empowered Groups which had been condensed to six from the original 11, in view of the progression of the pandemic and the need to club some issued under certain groups were once again expanded to 10 groups. This time however, their ambit was expanded to specifically look into issues of oxygen availability, vaccination, emergency response and economic welfare measures. Dr Paul continued to remain the convener for Empowered Group 1, which oversaw vaccination, vaccine procurement, import and such other issues. This was the third specialty group after the VTF and NEGVAC which dealt with vaccination-related decisions. However, while the VTF